



Firefox: Its Past, Present and ... Future?

If Google had sneaked in a crack sabotage team behind enemy lines at Mozilla, the tech giant could not have been more successful! Mozilla is on a self-destructive course — it has fired its CEO, abandoned pet projects, frustrated add-on writers with breaking API changes and annoyed users by disabling important functionality. Worst of all, Mozilla's obsession with Chrome may see it lose control of Firefox.

At the outset, let's look at the four primary reasons for Mozilla Firefox losing the browser wars to Google Chrome:

- For one, the vast majority of people use a browser solely as a means to an end. They use a particular software only because somebody told them to. There is not too much of thought that goes into this nor sentiments attached to it. When Microsoft Internet Explorer (IE) was ruling the Web, these people would hit the IE icon and wait patiently as the browser got automatically redirected from Microsoft.com to MSN.com and then to MSN.in. Even after that, the wait would continue because IE would become unresponsive as it loaded big blobs of images, CSS and JavaScript frameworks. Only after at least one or two minutes of this, could people click the address bar and type in some URL! It would never occur to them that they could easily change the home page to *about:blank* and avoid all that waiting. Most people never change their software settings. They always work with defaults. When Chrome was started, it loaded a blank page almost immediately. "Chrome loads so fast!" people would gush
- When Chrome was installed, it would be to the user's 'Application Data' directory. This was, until then, a tactic used mostly by malware programs. This enabled Google to bypass user account restrictions on installing new software. Even a 'Guest' account user could install Chrome!
- The third reason is that most people are unquestioning rule-followers and compulsive clickers. If an online ad says, "Here, click to install this toolbar/screensaver," they obediently click on it. Or, if somebody announces a bereavement on Facebook, they impulsively 'Like' it! Most browsers had Google as the default search engine. At the top of every search results page, Google would implore the user to install the Chrome browser. There was no escape. People downloaded it and it took over the machine. There was no going back. Chrome did not load a home page and it had no UI. Where was the need for a UI? Most users did not even know how to change their home page to blank! Google knew this and Chrome was made to take advantage of it.
- Microsoft's reaction to Chrome has ranged from generally lethargic to hilariously pathetic. After winning the browser wars against Netscape, it spent some time with its 'Embrace, extend and extinguish' strategy. After that, it lost interest and stopped doing any major work on the